

driver of the business. A college dropout, Shevlin, entered the army where he trained and worked as an electronics technician. He didn't care too much for the military's uptight attitude. After a brief stint, he left the army. Shevlin was unemployed and without much money. He lived in a tiny studio apartment in Florida.

It was the very early days of the personal computer (PC) business and Shevlin, being a hacker type, had a computer and a printer in his studio. The ideal setup required the printer to be placed away from the PC and he needed a 20-foot cable to connect them. He went to a shop that sold printer cables and computer accessories and asked if they had the long cable he needed.

At that time, when PCs were very new, the interfaces for all these cables were not universal or standard as they are today. There was a hodgepodge of different cabling and socket standards. The retailer said he had the cable but it was only seven feet long. He suggested daisy-chaining three cables and adding some special connectors to make it all work. Shevlin was not happy with the total price or nature of the proposed solution.

He went back to his studio and thought about the situation. He came back to the retailer and said that he had been a tech in the army and knew how to make PC cables. He offered to make and sell cables in a variety of lengths to the retailer. The retailer said that he was used to getting all sorts of requests for cables of different lengths that he did not have an ability to procure or provide. Nonetheless, the retailer was hesitant about taking inventory risk on unbranded cables as some of the inventory might become obsolete quickly. Shevlin offered to give it to him on consignment. The retailer said that on a consignment basis, he'd stock anything. So Shevlin was in business with the first customer lined up.

Shevlin and Wilkin carefully noted all the missing cable lengths and connectors that people might want. They bought 300 feet of cable and all the hardware to make the various connectors and went to work. They made various odd-length cables and delivered them to the retailer who was elated. These cables cost about two to three dollars apiece to make. They gave them to the retailer at about \$16 apiece—which was very competitive with